

FUTURE IN FOCUS
Rahul Gandhi and Farooq Abdullah with other coalition leaders in Anantnag, Sept. 4; (left) locals queue up to vote in Pulwama, Sept. 18

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THE NATIONAL CONFERENCE HAS TIED UP WITH THE CONGRESS TO BOLSTER ITS CHANCES OF WINNING THE SEATS IN JAMMU AND DENTING THE BJP TALLY

Meanwhile, the PDP has seen a minor rejig after some of its political leaders returned to the party. Its winnability seems low, though, given that it led only in five assembly segments out of the 54 in Kashmir in the Lok Sabha polls. Besides two other seats, even party president Mehbooba Mufti lost from family bastion Anantnag-Rajouri. While she herself is not contesting this time, Mehbooba is fielding daughter Iltija from the very constituency she made her electoral debut from in 1996—Bijbehara-Srigufwara. The party, though, has witnessed the exit of young leaders over the allocation of tickets, further denting its poll prospects. But Iltija, who is contesting for the first time, believes that more than anything else, "the sense of disempowerment in Kashmir is acute, especially among the young. The pro-India space—those of us who kept the national flag—is shrinking. The government is trying to obliterate the middle ground."

Many of these leaders, including Sajad Lone, accuse the BJP of engineering a majority by propping up Independents, but warn that encouraging separatists to dent the votes of the middle-grounders may have a blowback. Rashid, who has announced that he is tying up with the Jamaat, is cited as an example of the government's double standards. Altaf Bukhari says that at a time when a mere anti-government Facebook post can have serious consequences, someone like Rashid, who spouts azadi sentiments, is being encouraged. The NC sees it as a ploy to take the so-called sentiment vote away from it so that its seat tally gets reduced. Rana points out that all the mainstream parties have been in bed with the BJP before, so they have little reason to complain. Chugh dismisses talk of the BJP backing such elements with a Punjabi phrase, which roughly translates as "If I have planted wheat seeds, why should I reap a maize crop?"

Iltija, who is fond of watching *Squid Game*, thinks the outcome of the voting would be much like the end of the Korean series: there are no winners, only survivors. She says passionately, "Kashmir is integral to the soul of India—to its democracy, its ethos and its pluralism. To integrate, we need hearts, minds and feelings. Kashmir is not about economics or finance or politics. It is a humane and humanitarian issue. Our spirits are shattered, our hearts battered. We want resolution, reconciliation and to feel genuinely healed." One election may not offer a total solution. But it is a big step forward on the road to redemption. ■